

Nokia Mixed Reality concept

Check out the video of Nokia's Mixed Reality concept glasses

<http://dgit.in/nokiamixedreality>

From the labs

with numerous possible applications" AiRScouter is focused primarily at uses like assembly support in factories and are already available for sale in Japan.

If you thought that Google doesn't really have competition from these small-time companies, think again. In 2009, Nokia had released a strikingly similar concept video named "Nokia Mixed Reality" featuring gaze-tracking eyewear to browse and select with your eyes. Just like the Google video, it showed a day in the future, in which one could interact with people and devices in innovative ways. What it's doing with this invention today no one knows.

Last year, Sony demonstrated "Smart AR", a system it wants to integrate with its future gaming devices. It could, in the times to come, allow characters to appear on tabletops or respond to the movement of real objects or even build a rough 3-D map of a room.

How can we not mention Oakley, whose Thumps was said to be the inspiration for Project Glass. Right on the heels of Google's unveiling, Oakley announced that it too has been working on a similar technology since 1997. It's targeting sportspersons for starters and in the process of creating a self-contained unit that can communicate with smartphones. In its announcement, the company stated that the initial versions of such a product wouldn't be cheap while agreeing that the



iWear VR920 augmented reality glasses by Vuzix, in production since 2009, via Vuzix Store

"technology barrier to success is significant".

Since Google's announcement though, Oakley is not the only company to express similar plans. NASA recently announced its plans to make AR-enabled HUDs that would allow pilots to see through fog, and show flight info such

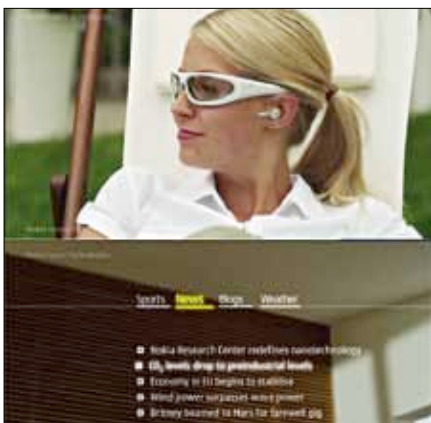
as airspeed, altitude etc. right in front of the pilot's eyes. America's DARPA who is already working on AR glasses for the battlefield, went one step ahead and announced investment into making prototype contact lenses with AR capabilities.

The skepticism

Looking at all the similar ventures already out there may make Project Glass look like a borrowed idea. But skeptics don't stop there. There are huge gaps in where the current technologies are and where Google is hoping to reach soon.

The lack of full lenses and the small, rectangular piece of glass hovering over the user's right eye raise the question as to how exactly wearers would be able to receive data over their entire fields of vision as the video seems to indicate. Also, practical doubts about making such an object almost omnipresent in society are just starting to roll in. Be it while talking to someone or driving down the road, if you're allowed to flip through graphical, textual or audio content, or even take pictures without anyone's knowledge, how safe and private our society would remain is a pressing question.

Seeing augmented reality tech being researched and adopted on such a scale compels us to arrive at the conclusion that Google is just hopping onto the AR bandwagon (and not too quickly either). Let's not forget though that the way Google has imagined the applications and uses of this very technology are far more immersive, impressive and exciting than those before it. It's the same way that Apple packaged mostly existing tech to give us the all new iPad. What Google is trying to do is add onto the existing technology to make it work for us like never before. **i**



Nokia's concept glasses and hearing aid

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